



PunkBackup — Troubleshooting Manual

This manual shows the app in **English** — go to "**Settings**" → "**English**" if it isn't already switched (instant, no restart).

The app closes by itself shortly after opening

This is Avast (or a similar antivirus), not a bug in PunkBackup — see the "Important: this app is not code-signed" section of the Installation Manual for why, and the fix (add an exception for the PunkBackup install folder in Avast, restore it from Quarantine/Virus Chest if it landed there).

"Start backup" does nothing / doesn't change state

- Fully close the app (not just minimize it) and reopen it from the Desktop icon.
- If it happens again, you should now get an error window with the exact detail (instead of failing silently) — send us that text.
- Make sure there isn't another copy of the app already open (check the taskbar).

The iPhone can't reach the server

1. Confirm the iPhone and the PC are on the **same WiFi network** (check the exact name in WiFi settings on both — some routers have separate 2.4GHz/5GHz networks with similar-looking names).
2. From Safari on the iPhone, try opening the address the app shows you (e.g. `http://PC-NAME.local:8787/health`). If it doesn't load, try the "Fallback IP" the app also shows.
3. Confirm the server is on in the PC app ("Status: Listening on port..."). It automatically retries a few times (briefly showing "Starting backup...") if the port doesn't free up right away — common right after antivirus software closes and reopens the app. If it still fails after those retries (e.g. the port is genuinely used by something else), the app shows a real error message explaining why instead of falsely claiming it's listening — if you see that error, close whatever else might be using port 8787 (or another copy of PunkBackup) and try again.
4. Check the Firewall rule exists: PowerShell (as administrator) → `Get-NetFirewallRule -DisplayName "PunkBackup"`. If it's missing (e.g. you skipped that checkbox during install), add it with `New-NetFirewallRule -DisplayName "PunkBackup" -Direction Inbound -Protocol TCP -LocalPort 8787 -Profile Private -Action Allow`.

401 error "Missing or invalid X-Backup-Token header"

- The token in the Shortcut doesn't match your profile's token on the PC.
- In the Shortcut, check **every** action with an X-Backup-Token header — the value must be the Token variable **chip** (colored background), never the literal word "Token" typed as plain text.
- Copy the token again from the app ("Copy token" button on the profile) and paste it into the corresponding **Text** action in the Shortcut.

403 error "This profile is paused"

- The profile is **Paused**. Open the app → "Main" or "Settings" → switch it to **Active**.

409 error "no destination folder configured"

- That profile has no destination folder. Go to "**Settings**" → "Choose folder..." for that profile.

The Shortcut runs but doesn't upload any new photo

- Check "**Find Photos**" has no stray filter beyond the Date Taken is before **Limite** one described in the iPhone Setup Manual — a different filter sneaking in makes it return 0 results silently, with no visible error.
- Check **Limit** is turned **on** and set to **50** on Find Photos — this is mandatory (not optional): without it, Find Photos fails outright on a large library, even doing nothing but counting results.
- Confirm under **iPhone Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Photos** that the Shortcuts app has access ("All Photos" / "Always Allow") — with limited access, a photo you just took or saved may simply not be visible to the Shortcut yet, with no error shown.

All new photos are landing in the same folder (the current month)

This happens when the server receives an empty date for each photo, and `_year_month_dir()` falls back to "right now" — so everything ends up in the current month's folder regardless of when the photo was actually taken.

- **Almost always confirmed cause:** the chip inside the **Format Date** action (the one that builds the TakenAt variable, section 4 of the iPhone Setup Manual) got silently reconfigured to point at a different attribute (e.g. "Name") instead of **Date Taken**. This usually happens with no visible error, right after adding or moving another action inside the same "Repeat" block — Shortcuts sometimes silently reconfigures neighboring chips.
- **How to confirm it:** inside the Shortcut, open section 4's "Format Date" action and tap its chip — it should say **Date Taken**. If it says anything else, that's the problem.
- **Fix:** re-select "Date Taken" on that chip. Photos uploaded AFTER this fix will land in their correct folder automatically — nothing else needs to change for new uploads.
- **Photos already uploaded to the wrong folder** (before the fix) don't reorganize themselves — they stay where they landed. If this happened to a large number of files, it's a one-off maintenance job (reading the

real date directly from each file, or forcing a re-send from the phone), not something the Shortcut or server fixes automatically.

A video shows today's date in another app (PhotoPrism, Finder...), even though it's in the right Year/Month folder

This is expected and already fixed automatically — nothing you need to do. Some videos (mainly ones imported from other apps, not straight from the camera) need an automatic retry to upload correctly at all; that retry process used to leave the video's own internal date stamp set to the day it was retried, instead of the real recording date — even though the folder it landed in was always correct. The server now corrects that internal date automatically for every video it receives, and already went back and fixed every video backed up before this correction existed. If you still see a wrong date in another app after this, that app may simply be reading a different field than the one being corrected — not something to chase further on the PunkBackup side.

My library is huge (thousands of photos) — will the full backup ever finish?

The Shortcut sweeps your library backward in bounded blocks of 50, newest photos first, advancing automatically block after block within one run — see the "Set up the backward block-sweep" step of the iPhone Setup Manual. This is what makes a large library actually finish, instead of either timing out (no `Limit`) or getting stuck re-checking the same fixed set forever (a plain `Limit` with no way to advance).

- The number of blocks per run is controlled by the `Repeticiones` variable (a `Text` action near the top, defaults to 50). Confirmed working with `Repeticiones` up to 50 (≈2500 photos checked in one run). For your very first full backfill of a large library, it's fine to run the Shortcut several times in a row rather than pushing `Repeticiones` very high on the first try — watch the PC app's activity log (use "Expand" for a bigger view) to see it's keeping up before raising the number.
- **Videos can currently arrive empty (0 bytes) — sometimes consistently, not just occasionally.** The server always detects and rejects this automatically, so it's never recorded as a real backup and the same video is simply retried on a later run instead — but the underlying cause (why the iPhone sometimes sends an empty body for a video specifically) isn't fully understood yet: it's not iCloud storage optimization, not a fixed file-size limit, and it isn't reliably fixed by keeping the Shortcuts app in the foreground either — this is an open issue, not a solved one. Photos are unaffected (confirmed reliable). Keeping the screen on and the Shortcuts app in the foreground during a large manual run may still help, and does no harm, but don't count on it fixing every case.
- If a run gets interrupted (you leave home, or tap Stop), nothing is lost — anything already uploaded stays backed up permanently. The next run just starts sweeping from your newest photos again rather than exactly where it left off; the already-completed blocks re-check quickly (no file transfer) before it reaches new ground.
- If the Shortcut itself appears to freeze with no error and no visible cause (rare, but a known Shortcuts app quirk unrelated to this system), force-quit it from the app switcher and run it again — nothing gets corrupted by an interrupted run, see the point above.

How fast is a backup, really? (measured in this environment)

These numbers come from real production uploads on this project's own setup — an **iPhone 15**, a **home WiFi network**, and a **Windows PC (Dell)** — derived directly from the server's own timestamps for every file it has ever received (over 7,200 real photos/videos), not a lab benchmark.

File type	Share of a typical library	Avg. file size	Typical time per file
JPEG	~55%	0.24 MB	~2 s
HEIC	~33%	2.1 MB	~5.5 s
PNG	~5%	2.4 MB	~5.3 s
MP4	~4%	8.0 MB	~10 s
MOV	~3%	31.5 MB	~19 s

Most of the time for a small photo is **not** network transfer — it's the fixed overhead of the Shortcut's two requests per item (`/check`, then `/upload`). That overhead barely changes with file size, so it dominates small photos and matters less and less for bigger videos, where actual transfer speed becomes the main factor.

Projection, assuming a library with a similar photo/video mix as the one measured above (mostly photos, roughly 1 in 14 items a video):

Library size	First-time full backup (approx.)
1,000 new items	~1 h 10 min
5,000 new items	~5 h 50 min
10,000 new items	~11 h 45 min

Caveats: - This is for the **first** backup of brand-new files. Routine backups (re-checking files already backed up) are much faster per item, since most items get skipped after a quick `/check` with no file transfer. - Your own photo/video mix shifts these numbers — a video-heavy library takes noticeably longer per item than a photo-heavy one. - One Shortcut run is capped by `Repeticiones` (confirmed working up to 50 blocks, ≈2,500 items, in one run) — a 10,000-item first backfill needs roughly 4 separate runs, not one continuous run. - Your own WiFi signal strength and other devices competing for bandwidth at the same time will shift these numbers in either direction.

The phone freezes while the Shortcut runs

- Go to **iPhone Settings** → **Display & Brightness** → **Auto-Lock** → **Never** (temporarily, while running a large backup).
- Runs with thousands of photos can take several minutes — that's normal, not a freeze.
- If it truly stops responding: a forced restart of the iPhone is safe, nothing is lost (the server-side run is just left unfinished, harmlessly).

The Shortcut's final notification shows blank numbers (New/Already had/Conflicts)

This never affects the actual backup — files keep uploading and saving correctly even when the notification comes back blank. If it happens, check the **"Get Contents of URL"** action pointing at `/run/finish` (section 5 of the iPhone Setup Manual):

- The `X-Backup-Token` header must be under **Headers**, not inside **Request Body** → **Form**.
- **Request Body** → **Form** needs a `run_id` field set to the `RunID` variable — without it, the server rejects the request and the rest of that section (reading the counters, building the message) gets silently skipped, leaving the summary blank.

To confirm something was really saved while you check, look at the destination folder directly (see next section).

How to check files are really being saved

No technical steps needed: open the destination folder you chose in Windows Explorer — you should see Year/Month subfolders with your photos and videos inside.

Still not working

Contact whoever helped you install the system, or check the project's GitHub repository to report the issue.